

Case Study: Aurelia Motion Systems – Roles, Knowledge, and Expertise

Opening

On a rainy Monday in March 2026, Elena Vogt, CEO of Aurelia Motion Systems, received two messages about the same AI system. The first came from the CFO and was optimistic: “NOVA allows our senior account managers to cover more business without adding headcount.” The second came from the HR director and sounded less reassuring: “Several junior sales employees say they are learning the system faster than they are learning sales.”

Aurelia Motion Systems was a German automotive supplier with around 1,500 employees. The company produced precision components for thermal management systems, sensor housings, and lightweight assemblies for European carmakers and tier one suppliers. By 2026, the company faced strong cost pressure, unstable electric vehicle programs, and declining demand in several combustion related product lines. Six months earlier, Aurelia had introduced an AI supported sales suite called NOVA to increase sales productivity and improve decision quality.

NOVA seemed to help. Senior account managers prepared faster for customer meetings. Sales dashboards looked cleaner. Customer requests received earlier responses. Yet the leadership board began to hear a different concern. The same tool that expanded the reach of experienced people might also change how less experienced employees developed judgment.

Elena summarized the issue for the external consulting team: “We bought NOVA to improve productivity. I now need to know whether we are also changing the future knowledge base of the sales organization. Who is learning more, who is learning less, and what new roles have we created without naming them?”

The consultants should analyze the evidence and prepare a recommendation for the leadership board. The question was not whether AI could support sales work in general. The question was how Aurelia should design roles and learning around NOVA before scaling the system further.

A short guide to terms used in this case

Term	Plain meaning for this case
NOVA	The name of Aurelia's AI supported sales suite. It combines forecasting, opportunity scoring, and proposal drafting.
NOVA Forecast	A tool that compares customer schedules, order histories, CRM entries, and market signals to highlight likely changes in demand.
NOVA Signal	A tool that produces customer and opportunity scores. Sales managers use these scores to prioritize requests.
NOVA Quote	A tool that drafts proposal documents by drawing on previous proposals, engineering documents, customer messages, price lists, and margin rules.
Series Sales	The sales team responsible for established products and recurring business with major customers.
New Mobility Sales	The sales team responsible for newer electric vehicle, battery, and sensor related opportunities. Requests are often less standardized.
Sales Operations	The team that maintains CRM data, prepares sales reports, monitors sales process quality, and supports pricing analysis.

How sales expertise developed before NOVA

Before NOVA, Aurelia's sales expertise developed through participation in imperfect work. Junior employees prepared first summaries of customer requests, searched for comparable projects, drafted internal notes on price and delivery assumptions, and collected open questions for engineering. Their drafts were often incomplete. That was part of the learning process. Senior account managers corrected them, explained customer histories, and showed how technical uncertainty, customer politics, and margin pressure had to be read together.

The old process was not ideal. It was slow and uneven. Some juniors spent days formatting proposals, searching old files, or copying technical descriptions from previous documents. Others learned a great deal because their managers used the early drafts as teaching material. There was no formal apprenticeship program. Learning depended on whether a senior manager had time and whether a customer request was complex enough to reveal judgment.

Two sales teams offered different learning environments. In Series Sales, juniors learned how to read recurring customer patterns, volume changes, and annual price negotiations. In New Mobility Sales, they learned how to work with uncertain specifications, incomplete customer sketches, and early electric vehicle projects where technical and commercial assumptions shifted quickly.

How NOVA changed the path into expertise

NOVA changed work without formally changing job descriptions. In Series Sales, senior account managers started their week with NOVA alerts instead of full manual account reviews. In New Mobility Sales, proposal drafts could be generated before a junior employee had assembled the first interpretation. Sales Operations became more important because NOVA depended on clean CRM records, current customer classifications, and meaningful comments when managers overruled AI recommendations.

Hannah Weiss, a senior account manager in Series Sales, described NOVA as a relief: “I still need to understand the customer. But I no longer waste half of Monday finding out which accounts deserve attention. NOVA gives me the five conversations that probably matter.”

Lara Pohl, a junior analyst, described the same change differently: “I can explain why an alert appeared. I can correct the customer segment. But I join fewer customer calls because the first version is already there. I know NOVA better than before, but I am not sure I know the customers better.”

Sales Operations experienced another shift. Lena Hartmann, who managed CRM quality, said: “We used to be the reporting team. Now we are the people who make the AI usable. But officially, nothing changed. The dashboard fails when the data are bad, and everyone sees the dashboard, not the work behind it.”

Exhibit 1. Selected indicators reviewed by the leadership board

Indicator	Baseline, August 2025	March to	Series Sales after rollout	New Mobility pilot after rollout
Average number of active customer accounts per senior account manager	18		24	21
First proposal summaries prepared by junior employees per month	46		21	17
Customer calls attended by junior employees per month	38		24	19
Average hours per week spent on CRM correction in Sales Operations	22 hours		41 hours	39 hours
Formal AI training hours per sales employee	0		4 hours	4 hours
Reported confidence in “understanding why NOVA made a recommendation”	Not measured		Senior employees, high. Junior employees, mixed	Mixed across both groups
Proposal drafts returned by engineering for major revision	18 percent		20 percent	37 percent

Two different ways of using NOVA

The digital transformation team observed that NOVA did not have one learning effect. The effect depended on how managers used the tool. Some managers used NOVA as a comparison partner. They asked junior employees to prepare their own view before looking at the AI output. Others used NOVA to bypass the first draft stage almost entirely.

Sabine Keller, a senior manager in Series Sales, asked juniors to write a short note before opening NOVA Signal. “I want them to say which account they would prioritize and why. Then we compare it with NOVA. Sometimes the system is better. Sometimes they are. The learning is in the difference.”

Jonas Ritter, another senior manager, used NOVA differently. He said: “We are under productivity pressure. I cannot recreate the old training model just because the tool is faster. Juniors should learn to work with the system. That is the new job.”

The difference became visible in New Mobility Sales. Felix Brandt used NOVA Quote to generate alternatives and then asked younger colleagues to identify missing assumptions. Mira Scholz, a proposal coordinator, said she often received AI drafts that were already framed as almost complete. “When the draft looks polished, it is hard to ask basic questions. You feel like the slow person in the room.”

Exhibit 2. Extracts from internal learning observations

Employee	Observation extract
Lara Pohl, junior analyst, Series Sales	Tuesday, 10:35 a.m. Lara corrects duplicate customer records and adds missing segment codes. She says she used to prepare first summaries for Hannah, but now “the first version is already there.” Later she asks to join a customer call. Hannah replies that the call will be short because NOVA has narrowed the issue.
Sabine Keller, senior account manager, Series Sales	Wednesday, 9:00 a.m. Sabine asks two juniors to rank five customer alerts before revealing the NOVA score. She spends twenty minutes discussing why one low score may still require attention because the customer’s purchasing team recently changed.
Jonas Ritter, senior account manager, Series Sales	Wednesday, 4:15 p.m. Jonas tells the team to “trust the queue unless there is a clear reason not to.” His juniors update CRM records while he handles two customer calls alone.
Felix Brandt, business development manager, New Mobility Sales	Thursday, 11:20 a.m. Felix asks NOVA Quote for three proposal versions. He asks a junior colleague to mark assumptions that require engineering input. The junior identifies a missing tooling assumption, but says he would not have noticed it without Felix’s prompt.
Lena Hartmann, Sales Operations	Friday, 9:30 a.m. Lena reviews override comments for the board dashboard. Several comments read “customer special case.” She says she is becoming an informal AI interpreter because managers ask her why NOVA produced certain scores.

A dispute about training and responsibility

HR proposed a two day “AI Sales Academy” for all sales employees. The CFO questioned whether this would solve the problem. “People do not need another workshop. They need to use the tool in their daily work,” he said. The HR director replied that daily use was exactly the issue because some daily use patterns separated juniors from the situations in which they previously learned judgment.

Engineering also entered the discussion. Sven Richter, an engineering team lead, argued that sales employees needed enough technical understanding to know when a NOVA Quote draft was fragile. “If sales cannot see the missing assumption, engineering becomes the correction department. That is not expertise development. That is rework.”

The works council raised a different concern. If AI use became a core sales skill, employees who were slower with NOVA might be seen as less competent even when they had strong customer judgment. At the same time, employees who could operate NOVA quickly might appear competent without understanding the customer or the product deeply.

Elena asked the board to avoid a simple generational story. “This is not young people versus experienced people. Some seniors hide behind the tool, and some juniors challenge it well. I need a role and learning model that makes good use visible.”

The board discussion

At the March board meeting, the leadership team considered several options. One option was to scale NOVA quickly and let local managers decide how to train their teams. Another was to pause scaling until new role descriptions and learning routines were defined. A third option was to scale the forecasting and scoring modules while keeping proposal drafting in a controlled pilot. A fourth option was to redesign role expectations before any further expansion.

The Head of Sales wanted flexibility. He argued that strict rules would slow the productivity gains. HR wanted a clearer development path for junior employees. Sales Operations wanted formal recognition for data stewardship. Engineering wanted sales employees to remain responsible for identifying uncertainty before proposals arrived for validation.

Elena closed the discussion with a question for the consulting team: “Are we using NOVA to strengthen the sales organization’s knowledge, or are we using it to concentrate expertise in a few people and a dashboard? I need a recommendation that treats productivity and learning as connected.”

Your consulting task

You are consultants advising Elena Vogt and the leadership board of Aurelia Motion Systems. Your group focuses on how NOVA changes roles, knowledge, and expertise. Your task is not to judge whether AI is generally useful. Your task is to recommend how Aurelia should design roles and learning around NOVA before scaling it further. Prepare a board pitch. Your pitch should use evidence from the case and end with a concrete concept that the board could adopt. In particular, Elena Vogt is interested in the following questions:

1. What is the central roles and expertise problem created by NOVA? Use evidence from Series Sales, New Mobility Sales, Sales Operations, and the learning observations.
2. What should Aurelia do next: scale NOVA broadly, restrict it to selected work, continue the pilot, or redesign roles and learning routines before scaling? Justify your choice and discuss the main trade off.
3. Develop a Human AI Expertise Development Concept with up to five rules. Specify how employees should learn with NOVA, who should explain and challenge AI outputs, and which new roles need formal recognition.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop this case.